

# SENATE . . . . . No. 929

## The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

PRESENTED BY:

***James B. Eldridge***

*To the Honorable Senate and House of Representatives of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts in General Court assembled:*

The undersigned legislators and/or citizens respectfully petition for the adoption of the accompanying bill:

**An Act relative to debt-free public higher education.**

PETITION OF:

| NAME:                      | DISTRICT/ADDRESS:                                     |                  |
|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| <i>James B. Eldridge</i>   | <i>Middlesex and Worcester</i>                        |                  |
| <i>Vanna Howard</i>        | <i>17th Middlesex</i>                                 | <i>2/11/2025</i> |
| <i>Jacob R. Oliveira</i>   | <i>Hampden, Hampshire and Worcester</i>               | <i>2/11/2025</i> |
| <i>Mike Connolly</i>       | <i>26th Middlesex</i>                                 | <i>2/11/2025</i> |
| <i>Manny Cruz</i>          | <i>7th Essex</i>                                      | <i>2/27/2025</i> |
| <i>James K. Hawkins</i>    | <i>2nd Bristol</i>                                    | <i>2/27/2025</i> |
| <i>Joanne M. Comerford</i> | <i>Hampshire, Franklin and Worcester</i>              | <i>2/27/2025</i> |
| <i>Patricia D. Jehlen</i>  | <i>Second Middlesex</i>                               | <i>2/27/2025</i> |
| <i>Sal N. DiDomenico</i>   | <i>Middlesex and Suffolk</i>                          | <i>2/27/2025</i> |
| <i>Paul W. Mark</i>        | <i>Berkshire, Hampden, Franklin and<br/>Hampshire</i> | <i>4/18/2025</i> |
| <i>Adam Gómez</i>          | <i>Hampden</i>                                        | <i>4/18/2025</i> |
| <i>Rebecca L. Rausch</i>   | <i>Norfolk, Worcester and Middlesex</i>               | <i>5/28/2025</i> |
| <i>Pavel M. Payano</i>     | <i>First Essex</i>                                    | <i>6/23/2025</i> |

# SENATE . . . . . No. 929

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By Mr. Eldridge, a petition (accompanied by bill, Senate, No. 929) of James B. Eldridge, Vanna Howard, Jacob R. Oliveira, Mike Connolly and other members of the General Court for legislation to guarantee debt-free public higher education. Higher Education.

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[SIMILAR MATTER FILED IN PREVIOUS SESSION  
SEE SENATE, NO. 823 OF 2023-2024.]

## The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

\_\_\_\_\_  
In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court  
(2025-2026)  
\_\_\_\_\_

An Act relative to debt-free public higher education.

*Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:*

1           SECTION 1. Section 1 of chapter 15A of the General Laws, as appearing in the 2022  
2   Official Edition, is hereby amended by inserting after the word “opportunities”, in line 14, the  
3   following words:-

4           It is hereby further declared to be the policy of the commonwealth to guarantee free  
5   public higher education as a right for all residents.

6           SECTION 2. Chapter 15A of the General Laws is hereby amended by inserting after  
7   section 45 the following section:-

8           Section 46. (a) Definitions

9 As used in this section, the following words shall have the following meanings, unless the  
10 context clearly requires otherwise:

11 “Board”, the Board of Higher Education.

12 “Eligible Student”, any person admitted to Massachusetts public college or university or  
13 other public certificate, vocational, or adult education program, enrolled full-time or part-time,  
14 other than a nonimmigrant alien within the meaning of paragraph 15 of subsection (a)(A)  
15 through (S) of 8 U.S.C., section 1101 of the federal act, who has attended a high school in the  
16 commonwealth for 3 or more years and has graduated from a high school in the commonwealth  
17 or attained the equivalent thereof from an adult basic education program in the commonwealth,  
18 or is currently a student in a Massachusetts public higher education institution qualifying for in-  
19 state tuition under federal regulations, shall be eligible at any state institution of higher education  
20 in the commonwealth. The Legislature finds that this is a state law within the meaning of 8  
21 U.S.C. 1621(d).

22 (b) Notwithstanding the provisions of any general or special law to the contrary, the  
23 board shall create a grant program to pay the equivalent of tuition and mandatory fees to an  
24 eligible student at any Massachusetts public college or university, or certificate, vocational or  
25 training program at a public institution. Students meeting the income eligibility for Federal Pell  
26 Grants shall receive additional aid in grants to pay for the additional costs of attendance as  
27 calculated by the academic institution of enrollment, including, but not limited to, room and  
28 board, books and supplies, transportation and personal expenses.

29 (c) The grant shall supplement and shall not replace state grants, gift aid, institutional aid,  
30 or federal aid through the Free Application for Federal Student Aid process. The board shall

31 promulgate regulations to ensure funds from this program do not affect eligibility for other state  
32 grants, gift aid, institutional aid, or federal aid through the Free Application for Federal Student  
33 Aid process.

34 (d) All public higher education and public vocational training institutions shall be  
35 considered eligible institutions for this program and there shall be no restrictions on a student's  
36 choice of academic programs.

37 (e) The board shall provide an annual notice of eligibility for this program to all eligible  
38 students and all new graduates from a Massachusetts high school or GED program. The board  
39 shall maintain a database of all students currently or potentially eligible for this program.